Horicon Bank

Pre-Engagement Assessment

PREPARED BY	DATE	ENGAGEMENT
BrandThnk	February 20, 2026	Validation Sprint

Executive Summary

Horicon Bank has strong foundational elements in place: a clear strategic vision, defined themes, emerging governance structures, and a solid tech stack. The team is thinking about the right things.

The gap is in execution readiness. Current work relies heavily on segmentation tool outputs rather than synthesized, actionable personas. The path forward is consolidation and connection — fewer personas, tied to journeys, framed around customer aspirations.

The kickoff conversation with Rose confirmed the persona work is still in infancy and not yet used by frontline teams. It also surfaced three immediate opportunities: the senior market in southeast Wisconsin (minimal competition), the Bank at Work program (deposit conversion from existing business loan customers), and a refined nonprofit strategy separate from the church approach.

This Validation Sprint will confirm what's working, identify what needs to change, and provide a clear roadmap for the work ahead.

Current Context

Team situation: Marketing manager Grace recently left. Rose (SVP) is now directly overseeing the marketing team alongside trust department and business development officers. The team has capacity and ambition but needs strategic direction.

Market challenge: Milwaukee and southeast Wisconsin remain difficult to crack. New branches (Berman, Tosa, Cornerstone merger locations) haven't delivered the growth expected. "If you build it, they will come" hasn't worked — the bank needs a more deliberate go-to-market approach.

Deposit priority: Like most community banks, deposits are the primary growth lever. Several programs are in motion, but they need prioritization and clearer targeting.

What We Reviewed

- 2026 Customer Personas (PowerPoint)
- 2026 Marketing Strategy Framework (draft)
- 2026 Marketing Plan (draft)
- 2026 Brand Guide
- Branch Optimization Study
- Weekly Marketing Meeting Agenda
- Discovery call notes (December 2025)
- Kickoff conversation with Rose (February 18, 2026)

Strengths: What You Have

Strategic Foundation

Vision: "Persona-led growth engine" — this is the right direction. Marketing is positioned as a driver of deposit growth and customer acquisition, not just a communications function.

Strategic Themes: Well-defined and aligned to business priorities:

- Customer Experience
- Community Engagement
- Competitive Differentiation
- Technology Integration
- Market Expansion & Penetration

130th Anniversary: Smart positioning. Using longevity as a narrative thread (not just a campaign) reinforces trust in emerging markets like Milwaukee and Fox Valley.

"Together. Doing Good." Confirmed as the stronger direction. "The Natural Choice" is tied to Horicon Marsh — it doesn't resonate in Milwaukee where customers don't know the city or the marsh. "Together. Doing Good." connects to community involvement, the 130th anniversary, and the culture (40 hours paid volunteer time for all employees).

Operating Infrastructure

Governance: Monthly standups and quarterly reviews are planned. Cross-functional ownership is defined.

Tech Stack: Total Expert, Alkami (Segmint, Array), AnalyzerIQ, Vertical IQ. You're not flying blind on data — the question is how to use it.

Campaign Planning: Specific campaigns mapped with KPIs. Q1-Q4 calendar exists (though "very fluid"). Programs are categorized (Primacy & Loyalty, Community Growth, Niche GTM, Persona Lifecycle).

Proven Programs

Senior Program: Huge existing base with strong results. Trust seminars averaging 100 attendees, generating new business. Estate planning partnerships with local attorneys. Funeral trust partnerships in development. Research shows minimal competition for senior programs in southeast Wisconsin — this is a clear opportunity.

Nonprofit Checking: Unique product that pays interest on checking balances. Recent nonprofit brought ~$1M in new deposits. Board members of nonprofits often high net worth individuals with additional banking needs.

Employee Benefit: 40 hours paid volunteer time for all employees — a differentiator that connects to "Together. Doing Good." and creates organic community presence.

Gaps: What's Missing

1. Segments ≠ Personas

The current work describes *who customers are demographically* (life stage, NAICS code, income band). It doesn't answer:

- What are they trying to accomplish?
- What's the narrative arc of their financial life?
- How does Horicon fit into their story — not just their wallet?

Confirmed in kickoff: Rose acknowledged the persona work is "in infancy" and frontline teams are not using it today. The segments came from a strategic planning session in late 2025, driven by data analytics. They're a starting point, not a destination.

2. Aspiration Before Demographics

Current personas lead with who customers *are*. Mature personas lead with what customers *want to become*.

This is the "Aspirations First" approach: goals before problems, future state before current state. It shifts the bank's role from "provider of products" to "partner in progress."

3. Journey Connection

Journeys are mentioned in the tech stack (Total Expert), but the persona work doesn't show explicit journey mapping. Best practice connects each persona to specific moments that matter — not just lifecycle stages, but decision points where Horicon can show up differently than competitors.

4. Operating Model Beyond Marketing

The current operating model is a marketing hierarchy: Themes → Programs → Campaigns. That's useful for marketing planning, but it doesn't clarify how the rest of the organization activates.

A full operating model defines three layers:

- **Frontline:** Branch staff, relationship managers — what do they say and do?
- **Midline:** Marketing, training, enablement — what systems support them?
- **Backline:** Strategy, leadership — what decisions guide it all?

This ensures persona work doesn't live only in marketing decks.

Immediate Opportunities

Three opportunities surfaced in the kickoff that could generate near-term lift:

1. Senior Market in Southeast Wisconsin

- Minimal competition for senior programs in the Milwaukee area
- Trust seminars already averaging 100 attendees with conversion to new business
- Estate planning and funeral trust partnerships expanding reach
- Clear connection to Wealthy Achievers and Upscale Empty Nesters segments

> **Recommendation:**
> Double down. This is a proven program with room to scale into underserved geography.

2. Bank at Work (Deposit Conversion)

- Business loan customers without deposit relationships represent a quick win
- Program includes employee benefits (up to $500 for checking, $300 off mortgage closing)
- Treasury management fee waivers for first 6 months
- Dedicated BDO in Milwaukee focused on this

> **Recommendation:**
> Prioritize. Rose requested the customer list — this should be a 90-day priority with clear metrics.

3. Nonprofit Strategy (Separate from Churches)

- Nonprofit checking pays interest — unique offering
- Recent nonprofit brought ~$1M in new deposits
- Board members = high net worth individuals with additional banking needs
- Church symposium ROI is questionable; nonprofit strategy is cleaner

> **Recommendation:**
> Separate nonprofits from churches as distinct strategies. Lead with nonprofits where the value proposition is clear and ROI is proven. Evaluate church strategy separately based on whether you're banking the institution or just engaging the congregation.

Validation Sprint Focus

Based on this assessment and kickoff conversation, the engagement will focus on:

Area	What We'll Do
Strategy Review	Validate current direction and persona approach
Recommendations Brief	Keep, change, add — with rationale
90-Day Priorities	Identify highest-impact next steps with clear owners
Messaging Spine	Draft core messages to guide near-term execution

Stakeholder Interviews

Scheduled 30-minute conversations to gather additional perspective:

Name	Role	Lens
Brenda Heteberg	Regional Manager, Southern Region	Frontline / Contrarian
Cassie Voight	Operations, Senior Management	Backline / Strategy
Chrissy	Data Analytics	CRM / Total Expert
Natalie Colleen	Marketing	Digital / Stepped up since Grace left

Rose will send intro email; Allison will schedule directly.

Initial Observations: Keep, Change, Explore

Keep

- "Together. Doing Good." — confirmed as the stronger direction
- 130th Anniversary as narrative thread
- Tech stack investments (Total Expert, AnalyzerIQ, Vertical IQ)
- Governance structure (monthly/quarterly cadence)
- Senior program — proven, scalable
- Nonprofit checking — unique, high-value
- 40 hours paid volunteer time — cultural differentiator

Change

- Retire "The Natural Choice" or limit to legacy markets where marsh resonance exists
- Separate nonprofit and church strategies — different value propositions, different buyers
- Consolidate ~13 segments to 3-4 actionable personas

- Get persona work into frontline hands — currently marketing-only

Explore (This Sprint)

- Bank at Work as 90-day deposit priority
- Senior market expansion in southeast Wisconsin
- Aspiration-first framing for core personas
- Operating model beyond marketing (Frontline/Midline/Backline)

What Success Looks Like

At the end of this engagement, Horicon will have:

1. **Validation:** Confirmation of what's working and what needs to change
2. **Direction:** A messaging spine that works for marketing and frontline
3. **Priorities:** A 90-day action plan with clear owners
4. **Clarity:** A roadmap for the persona and journey work ahead

The goal isn't more documentation. It's confidence in the path forward.